

Handout: *Blackwell Ch1, WVO Quine – “On What There Is”*

I. The Ontological Problem

The Problem: *What is there?* This apparently simple question turns out to be deceptively difficult to answer clearly, especially when we ask about what *does not* exist. As Quine puts it, everyone agrees that "there is what there is," but disputes arise over particular cases: whether things like Pegasus, numbers, or universals are among "what there is".

II. The Puzzle of Nonbeing: Plato's Beard

Quine begins by rehearsing an old philosophical problem—the *riddle of nonbeing*. This is the idea, going back to Plato, that nonbeing must in some sense *be*, or else we couldn't even say what it is that does not exist.

- When two philosophers disagree ontologically, the denier seems to be at a disadvantage: they can't even admit what the other asserts, without contradicting their denial.
- Example: If I say Pegasus does not exist, I still appear to refer to something—*Pegasus*—and this seems to commit me to its being, even if only to deny it.

Quine refers to this problem as "**Plato's beard**"—a tangled doctrine that has dulled the edge of **Occam's razor**, the principle of ontological parsimony.

III. Bad Solutions: McX and Wyman

Quine uses fictional interlocutors to represent typical metaphysical positions:

- **McX** insists that we must admit Pegasus exists in some way, otherwise our statements about Pegasus are meaningless. He tries to locate Pegasus as an *idea* in the mind.
- **Quine's reply:** Confusing the *idea* of Pegasus with Pegasus itself is like confusing the *Parthenon* with the *idea of the Parthenon*—a category mistake.
- **Wyman** offers a more refined view: Pegasus is a *possible* but unactualized entity—a being that simply lacks actuality.
 - He draws a distinction between *existence* (actuality) and *subsistence* (being).

- **Quine's criticism:** This creates a bloated and chaotic "slum of possibles" filled with indeterminate and ontologically unruly entities. How many possible bald men are in that doorway? Are they the same as the possible fat men?
- This proliferation of possibilities raises questions of identity and individuation that cannot be resolved. Worse, it invites further absurdities: must we admit even *impossible* entities like "the round square cupola on Berkeley College"?

IV. The Solution: Russell's Theory of Descriptions

Russell's contribution allows us to affirm or deny the existence of entities referred to by **descriptions** without being committed to their existence. This is the key to cutting through *Plato's beard*.

Background on Russell's Theory

- A **definite description** is a phrase like "the present King of France" or "the author of *Waverley*".
- Russell analyzes such phrases as *not* names, but as logical constructions that can be paraphrased.

Example:

"The author of *Waverley* was a poet" becomes:

"There exists one and only one entity that wrote *Waverley*, and that entity was a poet."

Implication:

- The sentence is meaningful *even if* there is no such author. The term "the author of *Waverley*" does *not* need to name anything.
- Therefore, "The present King of France is bald" can be *false*, not *meaningless*, despite there being no such king.

Quine's Application

- Quine generalizes Russell's method: even proper names like *Pegasus* can be treated as shorthand for descriptive phrases (e.g., "the winged horse captured by Bellerophon").
- If no such entity satisfies the description, then "Pegasus does not exist" is just false—not nonsensical.
- We can avoid ontological commitment by replacing names with descriptions and then applying Russell's analysis.

Key Point: *A term can be significant without naming.* Meaning $\neq$ naming.

V. Ontological Commitment and Quantification

This leads to Quine's central ontological principle:

"To be is to be the value of a bound variable."

- That is, we commit to the existence of an entity *only if* our best theory quantifies over it.
- Saying "There is something that is a prime number larger than a million" commits us to *numbers*.
- But "Pegasus does not exist" does *not* commit us to Pegasus, because it can be paraphrased into a sentence that quantifies over nothing named "Pegasus".

Names are eliminable in principle. What matters is what our **quantifiers** range over.

VI. The Question of Universals

- McX insists on the existence of **attributes** (e.g., "redness") because red roses, houses, and sunsets must share *something*.
- Quine replies: We can describe such facts without postulating a shared universal entity. The word "red" simply applies to each item.

Rebuttal:

- McX insists that predicates must have *meanings*, and those meanings are universals.
 - Quine: You can accept that expressions are *significant* or *synonymous* without reifying meanings.
 - There is no need to posit "meaning entities" to explain meaningful language.
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VII. The Criterion for Ontological Commitment

Quine's proposal:

- **A theory is committed only to the entities over which its bound variables must range for the theory to be true.**
 - This gives a clear and rigorous criterion to evaluate what a theory assumes to exist.
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VIII. Ontological Disputes and Conceptual Schemes

- Ontological disputes often boil down to disagreements in **conceptual schemes**.
 - We choose between competing ontologies the way we choose between scientific theories: on pragmatic grounds like **simplicity** and **explanatory power**.
 - Quine compares physical objects and mathematical entities to “**myths**”—useful fictions that help us organize experience, even if they aren't reducible to sense-data.
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